

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS/AI**

ducer of pulses in the world, it is also their biggest importer. While India has creditably reduced this import dependence from 19 per cent of total demand to 9 per cent in the past decade, we are still nowhere near meeting the per capita protein requirement of our people. India will need a technological breakthrough in the next decade to achieve a Pulses Revolution to gain self-sufficiency in pulses production. Likewise, we import 60 per cent of our edible oil requirement, which is again the highest in the world. We need to make giant strides in boosting our vegetable oil production even as we keep environmental concerns in mind.

The same sorry tale attends India's defence programme too, with the country importing more than 60 per cent of its military equipment. If we are to retain our strategic independence, it is crucial that we push the pedal on indigenously making cutting-edge equipment such as jet engines and lethally-armed drones.

This leaves two other critical sectors—education and health—in which India needs transformative changes if it is to join the high table of developed nations. India may boast of a demographic advantage, with over 54 per cent of its population below the age of 25 years. But that advantage is undone by the huge skills gap. A recent UNICEF study showed that by 2030 over 50 per cent of India's youth will lack the necessary skills for employment. The Union and state governments, therefore, have to take urgent steps to reverse the situation and spend as much as it takes to do so. What is also needed is boosting—and more evenly spreading—STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics) curriculum education in India. Demand for STEM jobs rose by 44 per cent in the country between 2016 and 2019.

Equally important is improving the health delivery system to ensure quality, accessible and affordable services for the masses and deploying advanced solutions like gene therapy towards that endeavour. India also has a huge opportunity to regain self-reliance in manufacturing Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs)—the key components in any medicine—which it had ceded to China. Also, for making biosimilars, which promise to significantly reduce the cost of expensive drugs.

These 10 sectors are by no means an exhaustive list of the innovations and reforms India needs in its quest for first-world status. Rather, they are a roadmap for the country to focus its energies on what can best deliver citizen welfare. As the PM said in his I-Day speech, "The actions we take, the sacrifices we make, the penance we undertake in this era will lead to *Sarvajan Hitay, Sarvajan Sukhay* (the welfare and happiness of all)." There cannot be a nobler aspiration for India@100. ■